

Spiritual Maturity ch 2

Essential vocabulary

The study of Orthodox spiritual texts inevitably leads us into a Greek speaking world of the monastic life of the Byzantine (or better, Eastern Roman) Empire. While the Empire was multi-national, multi-ethnic, multi-lingual, the common language was Greek, which was the language of philosophy, education and literature. It was also the language of theology and spirituality, and had been for three hundred years before Christ. A second major language for theology and spirituality was Syriac, used in the Eastern areas of the Empire and particularly in Syria, Lebanon, Iraq. The great Fathers mainly spoke Greek, and some spoke Syriac. There has been significant work to bring their texts to the attention of the modern world, with translations and academic analysis. The publication of the ancient patristic materials into Western languages, especially English, has deeply affected the Church and the monastic life, enabling the faithful and the monks to access the wisdom of the great Fathers.

There are many terms familiar to English speaking readers that have different meanings than what comes from typical Western presuppositions, based on the Latin tradition. Words develop contextual meanings that may or may not carry over cultures. For example, “repent” carries the Latin emphasis on “Do Penance for your sins,” whereas the Greek (*metanoiete*) carries the literal meaning, “change your mind,” or as St Paul unpacks it in Romans 12:2, “Be transformed in the renewal of your mind.” This is very different!

Two more basic differences in presuppositions. In the Greek understanding of things, they do not talk about changing from stable states, as in from damned to saved by just saying a little prayer. This can be the beginning of repentance. But the Greek point is that it is a long, even life-long process, and it takes a lot of work and attention. This is an energetic paradigm, unlike the Western Latin idea, which deals with states of being, not development.

Other terms, like *nous*, never made it philosophically through the Middle Ages. It was redefined in the West, and lost much of its meaning. The Scriptural word *nous* was translated as intellect or mind, which does not convey the distinction in Greek between the rational mind and the spiritual mind. This will be dealt with in detail below.

Nous: the spiritual aspect of the soul, implanted at conception, making man a composite being, the nature of human beings, and the nature of the angels. Particular Fathers such as St Gregory of Nyssa, Basil the Great, Origen and Clement of Alexandria, and Maximos the Confessor, emphasize this duality. The *nous* bears within it the Image of God, which is the potential to attain to likeness to God, and hence the potential of

deification. The nous is impassible/unchangeable, incorruptible and unable to be damaged. It is the spiritual “organ” which perceives God and other noetic beings directly, not through the senses.

Repentance /Metanoia: metanoiēte, or metania: The meaning of repentance is revealed in Romans 12:2, “be transformed by the renewal of your nous.” This was the preaching of St John the Baptist, and taken up by Christ. Its not about guilt or shame, but rather spiritual transformation by uniting ourselves with Christ by the Holy Spirit. It also bears the sense of turning away from sin, renouncing and detaching from sinful thoughts, words and actions.

Natural/ Psychikos. “Psychikos” literally means soulish, as opposed to spiritual; also, psychological. The common translation in English bibles is “natural”, a very poor translation. In 1Corinthians 2-3, St Paul lays out the schema of Christian maturity; carnal, psychic and spiritual or noetic. The carnal man is preoccupied with sensual gratification and is oblivious to spiritual realities. The psychic man may have the beginnings of belief and faith, but is deeply ego-centric or self-centered. He may have a spiritual sense, but is rationalistic in his religious beliefs, subjecting all to his egocentric perspective. He would have the “form of religion, but denies its power.” He can grow beyond this through purification, and become authentically spiritual.

Spiritual /pneumatikos The spiritual man has undergone deep repentance and purification, has overcome ego-centrism, and begun to develop noetic awareness—the perception of the Presence of God and of grace. This is not rationalistic analysis but an intuitive (noetic) perception of the Divine and noetic, including of God as Persons, of angels and demons, and of noetic spiritual beings such as souls. It is developed by contemplative or noetic prayer, and does not use the senses, words or concepts, but intuitive awareness of God and His will. Its goal/telos is theosis, and the complete reintegration of our consciousness.

Purification/ catharsis Purification is an aspect of the process of growth, in which our mind, memory and will are cleansed of all memories, resentments, willful inclinations and addictive thought patterns of the passions. It is part of the process of taking control of our own mind, thoughts and memories, and not letting ourselves be manipulated by our passions. We have to confront ourselves, look at our inner processes, and own our own behaviors and thoughts, renounce and reject them, and detach from them. Then we take this to confession, to be cleansed by grace. This is repeated until we have detached and let go from these things, so they no longer bother us. This includes forgiving all who have hurt us. This is the first step on the road to repentance and transformation of mind.

Passions the Passions are habits that are so ingrained in us that we lose control over ourselves, and react in the same way when our mind is provoked. They become almost automatic, hence, passive reactions. The path to purification from the passions is to confront the passions, and bring our minds into custody, so we cut off the passionate reaction. The first stage is to cut off passionate actions or behaviors, next to recognize and cut off the thoughts, finally it is to remain unprovoked when a thought, emotion, memory or feeling hits us. Finally, the goal is to keep our minds pure and in deep peace.

Rational/ logiki. The soul has a rational aspect to it as well as a noetic aspect. The rational aspect of the soul manages all the data from the senses, what we learn, analyze, read, are taught. It is directly associated with the body. It is the realm of language, math, science, art, and all the various human disciplines. It uses rational logic to analyze the world. However, if it is not informed by the spiritual awareness, it can be oblivious to God and the spiritual realm. It is the very definition of psychikos. The ego is the self-concept of the rational mind, shaped by the passions. Once there has been a spiritual awakening, the rational mind begins to deal with the noetic awareness, to believe in God and salvation, and to integrate them, according to that spiritual consciousness.

Heart. The nous is often referred to as the heart. While it is in some sense “located” in the physical organ, the heart refers to the center of the man, of consciousness. In the Eastern tradition, the heart is not the center of emotions, feelings or sensations. These are from the rational aspects of our souls, and a kinds of thoughts (logismoi).

Stillness/ Hesychia. Stillness, or hesychia, is the primary practice of hesychasts, hermit monks living in deep stillness. Their spirituality is associated with the Jesus Prayer, but far transcends it. The Jesus Prayer is the means by which we enter into deep inner stillness, a place beyond words, thoughts, images or concepts; rather it is the pure awareness of Presence, and beyond.

Contemplation/ Theoria. Theoria means vision, as a type of prayer, and it refers to the noetic vision of those who have achieved a degree of maturity. It presumes the silencing of the mind and thoughts, of passions and all ego-centered prayer.

Deification/ Theosis. Theosis is the goal of spiritual life for Orthodox Christians, the height of spiritual maturity. It is a process that begins with conversion and baptism, and ends in the Resurrection, where radiant with the Uncreated Light we will be like Jesus as He is. Theosis is the fulfillment of repentance, with the sanctification of our whole being.

Dispassion/ apatheia. Dispassion or in Greek, *apatheia*, does not mean apathy. Rather is a state of being on the road to salvation and theosis, which is characterized by profound control over our minds, emotions, actions, behaviors; in short, non-reaction. We

can choose to respond rationally to a situation, provocation or memory without a reaction. This is the real content of sobriety. It is not to be emotionally flat. Rather, it is self-control no matter the challenge. We try to not react, but rather respond thoughtfully and rationally, and not lose control of ourselves, emotionally or otherwise, especially in areas where we have programmed ourselves to react in ways that are automatic (passionate) and harmful.